

AP-13: Silent Offboarding

Derivation Note 579 — Phase D3, Anti-Pattern 13

Taxonomy: Category 1 — Lifecycle Governance Failures (completing)

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This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

Silent Offboarding is the anti-pattern in which a Self stops participating in Full Aspect Integration (FAI) events without executing the governance offboarding sequence: standing configurations remain active, cross-organizational agreements are never terminated, partner Selves receive no notification, and no offboarding record is produced in the home substrate. The Self simply stops engaging while the governance infrastructure of its inter-Self relationships continues to exist as if engagement were ongoing. This note formalizes the anti-pattern across the seven-element Phase D3 structure, identifies the detection criteria that distinguish silent offboarding from legitimate temporary inactivity, traces the consequences for both the offboarding Self and its partners, explains why no clean intra-Self analog exists, and specifies the resolution. With AP-13 formalized, Category 1 of the Phase D3 taxonomy — Lifecycle Governance Failures — is complete.

1. Anti-Pattern Name and Category

Name: AP-13 — Silent Offboarding

Category: Category 1 — Lifecycle Governance Failures

Position in taxonomy: AP-13 is the third and final Category 1 anti-pattern. Category 1 covers failures at the three lifecycle junctures of a Self’s inter-Self participation: AP-11 (Governance Inception Failure) addresses the entry juncture, where a Self establishes FAI participation without the governance infrastructure entry requires; AP-12 (Configuration Drift) addresses the ongoing maintenance juncture, where a Self allows its standing configurations to diverge from its actual participation behavior without governance action; AP-13 addresses the exit juncture, where a Self stops participating without executing the governance sequence that exit requires. Together, AP-11,

AP-12, and AP-13 specify the three points at which lifecycle governance can fail. Category 1 is complete with this note.

2. Description

A Self's participation in inter-Self coordination is not merely behavioral — it is a governance state. Standing configurations, cross-organizational agreements, network participation preferences, and governance portfolio entries are all substrate content under Paper 3 Claim 5. They are authored under joint authority, they persist in the home substrate, and they remain active as governance artifacts until explicitly revoked or terminated through corresponding governance acts. Participation is not a property that simply expires when the Self stops showing up; it is a property that must be dissolved through governance.

Silent offboarding is the failure to dissolve this governance state when participation ends. The Self stops engaging in FAI events — ceases to initiate them, ceases to respond to partner-initiated events, effectively withdraws from inter-Self coordination — without executing any corresponding governance action. The standing configurations that enabled its FAI relationships remain in the home substrate with no revocation record. Cross-organizational governance agreements it entered remain nominally active with no termination notice. Partner Selves are not notified through formal governance channels. No offboarding record documents the wind-down decision, its effective date, or the rationale.

The result is a governance artifact without a governing intention behind it. The infrastructure of the relationship persists; the relationship itself has ended. From the governance record's perspective, nothing has changed. From the operational reality's perspective, the Self has left.

Silent offboarding is not negligence about record-keeping in the narrow sense. It is a violation of the architectural commitment that makes standing configurations meaningful as governance artifacts in the first place. If standing configurations can be created through governance acts but abandoned without governance acts, they are not, in any operational sense, governed. Paper 3 Claim 5's commitment — that all configurable dimensions of FAI participation are substrate content under joint human authority — requires that modification and revocation of that content occur through the same governance channel as creation. Abandonment is not revocation.

3. Detection Criteria

Silent offboarding is detectable through governance audit of the home substrate's record against the Self's actual participation history. One or more of the following conditions is sufficient to identify the pattern:

- **Standing configurations without revocation.** The home substrate contains standing configurations for FAI relationships with named partner Selves, but the Self has not engaged in FAI events with those partners for an extended period, and no revocation record or suspension record exists in the governance log. The configuration is active; the relationship is dormant.

- **Agreements without termination records.** Cross-organizational governance agreements appear in the governance portfolio as active, but no termination notice, termination confirmation from the partner, or termination record exists. The agreement is nominally binding; no party formally closed it.
- **Partner governance cannot locate formal notification.** When partner Selves conduct their own governance audits or attempt to confirm the status of the relationship, they find no formal notification of the offboarding through governance channels — no notice in their governance portfolio, no record of a dissolution event, no received offboarding record.
- **Network participation configuration inconsistent with behavior.** The Self's network participation configuration continues to indicate active participation in relationships the Self has behaviorally exited.
- **No offboarding record in home substrate.** The home substrate contains no offboarding record documenting the wind-down decision: no record of which relationships were closed, when the decision was made, what the rationale was, or which governance steps were executed.

A Self with legitimate temporary inactivity — absence due to operational circumstances, a deliberate pause with intent to resume, or a period of reduced engagement — is distinguished from a silently offboarding Self by the presence of governance documentation of that status. Legitimate inactivity leaves a record; silent offboarding leaves nothing.

4. Governance Commitment Violated

Primary violation — Paper 3 Claim 5 (configuration as substrate content): Claim 5 specifies that all configurable dimensions of FAI participation are substrate content under joint human authority. Standing configurations for FAI relationships are paradigm cases of this content: they specify which partner Selves the home Self engages, under what terms, with what merge preferences, and through what conflict-handling configurations. As substrate content under joint authority, standing configurations are subject to the same governance obligations as any other substrate content — they must be authored through governance acts, and they must be revoked through governance acts. Silent offboarding violates this commitment by abandoning standing configurations rather than revoking them. The configurations remain in the substrate as active substrate content, but no governing authority stands behind them. This is the configuration-as-substrate-content commitment violated at the revocation stage.

Secondary violation — exit rights governance (D2.46): Exit rights are the architectural entitlement of any Self to dissolve its inter-Self participation relationships. Exit rights governance specifies that the exercise of exit rights is itself a governance act — it produces records, it closes configurations through governance action, and it notifies partners through formal channels. Silent offboarding exercises the behavioral reality of exit while bypassing the governance sequence that makes exit a formal, recorded, substrated event. The exit right is invoked without the exit right's governance being executed.

Operational reference — D2.70 (seven-step offboarding sequence): D2.70 specifies the complete governance sequence for inter-Self offboarding across seven steps: decision record, partner notification, standing configuration revocation, agreement termination, governance portfolio update, network participation configuration update, and offboarding record production. Silent offboarding violates all seven steps simultaneously. It is not a partial execution of D2.70; it is the complete absence of D2.70.

5. Consequences

Silent offboarding produces consequences for both the Self that has silently exited and for the partner Selves whose governance infrastructure remains entangled with an inactive relationship.

For the Offboarding Self

- **Orphaned standing configurations and agreements.** The home substrate contains active governance artifacts — standing configurations, cross-organizational agreements, network participation entries — that no longer reflect any governing intention. They consume governance portfolio space, appear in governance audits as active relationships, and create a misleading picture of the Self's actual inter-Self engagement. The governance portfolio has become internally inconsistent: the record says one thing; operational reality says another.
- **Persisting agreement obligations.** Cross-organizational governance agreements that were not formally terminated may continue to impose obligations on the Self — obligations whose existence the Self may not be tracking because it has behaviorally disengaged. The Self has left the relationship without formally leaving the agreement.
- **Governance audit failure.** Future governance audits of the home substrate will find active governance infrastructure for relationships the Self believed it had exited. This is a governance integrity failure: the audit record cannot be trusted as an accurate representation of the Self's actual governance state, degrading the audit function precisely at the moments when governance accountability matters most.

For Partner Selves

- **Governance confusion about relationship status.** A partner Self whose governance record shows an active standing configuration and active agreement with the silently exiting Self cannot determine, from governance records alone, whether the relationship is active, dormant, or terminated. This is not a matter of missing information — it is a governance contradiction the partner cannot resolve without initiating contact outside formal governance channels.
- **Wasted governance resources.** Partner Selves may attempt to initiate FAI events under the still-active standing configurations, producing either ungoverned events that cannot complete because the offboarding Self is unresponsive, or governance confusion about whether to treat non-response as a temporary operational failure or evidence of relationship termination. Either way, governance resources are expended attempting coordination with a Self that has behaviorally exited without formal notice.

- **Loss of trust calibration.** Trust calibration between partner Selves is substrate-content — it accumulates through FAI event history and is updated through governance records of relationship evolution. When a Self stops participating without formal offboarding, partner Selves cannot update their trust calibration through the normal governance record. Unexplained non-responsiveness degrades trust calibration in a form that cannot be resolved through the governance record, because the governance record does not explain it.
- **No closure for governance portfolio.** Partner Selves cannot close their own governance portfolio entries for the relationship without either a formal notice from the offboarding Self or a unilateral governance determination that the relationship has ended. The latter requires the partner to make a governance judgment it is not architecturally positioned to make unilaterally, because the relationship's standing configurations and agreements were established under joint authority. The partner cannot formally exit a relationship whose governance the offboarding Self has simply abandoned.

6. Intra-Self Analog

No clean intra-Self analog exists for AP-13, and the absence is worth naming directly rather than forcing a parallel.

The Phase D3 taxonomy inherits its B3.xx analog structure from Phase B3 of the derivation series. Phase B3 anti-patterns formalize intra-Self failure modes — failures within a Self's internal architecture, within a Self's cell lifecycle, within a Self's evolutionary governance. Many Phase D3 anti-patterns inherit directly: the inter-Self FAI event is analogous to intra-Self mating; the inter-Self standing configuration is analogous to intra-Self aspect-membership configuration; the inter-Self governance portfolio is analogous to the intra-Self governance record.

Silent offboarding does not inherit cleanly because the intra-Self architecture does not have the concept that silent offboarding violates. Intra-Self architecture has no relationship portfolio — no set of standing configurations for maintained relationships with external parties, no cross-organizational agreements, no formal inter-entity governance commitments that persist across time as substrate content and require formal termination. Cells within a Self are born, operate, and die within the Self's governance perimeter. There is no analog to a Self that has entered ongoing governance relationships with other Selves under joint authority — relationships that persist, carry obligations, and require formal dissolution.

The closest intra-Self approximation would be a cell that ceases operational activity without the Self's governance executing the cell death sequence — the B3.17/B3.18 family of anti-patterns. But this parallel is structurally weak. A cell that stops operating leaves no external governance artifacts in a partner entity's governance portfolio; its absence is entirely internal to the Self. Silent offboarding's defining characteristic — that the failure imposes governance costs and governance confusion on external parties whose governance infrastructure remains entangled with the abandoned relationship — has no intra-Self counterpart.

Silent offboarding is a Paper 3 anti-pattern in the strict sense: it is a failure mode that the inter-Self scope introduces. Inter-Self relationship governance, with its standing configurations, cross-organizational agreements, joint-authority substrate content, and formal lifecycle sequences, is a Paper 3 invention. Some failure modes are specific to the scope at which they operate.

7. Resolution

The resolution to silent offboarding is the execution of D2.70's seven-step offboarding sequence. D2.70 is not merely a recommended practice; it is the architectural specification of what governed exit requires. Each step closes a specific governance gap that silent offboarding leaves open.

- **Step 1 — Decision record.** The offboarding decision is documented in the home substrate as a governance act: the Self's governance records that the decision to exit was made, by whom, on what date, and with what rationale. This step makes the exit decision itself a governed, substrated event rather than a behavioral outcome with no governance trace.
- **Step 2 — Partner notification.** Affected partner Selves are notified through formal governance channels — the same governance channel through which the relationship was established. Notification creates a governance record on the partner's side that the relationship is being formally closed.
- **Step 3 — Standing configuration revocation.** Each standing configuration for the exiting relationships is revoked through a governance act in the home substrate, with a revocation record documenting which configuration was revoked, when, and by reference to which decision record. Revocation is the governance act that closes the configuration as active substrate content.
- **Step 4 — Cross-organizational agreement termination.** Each cross-organizational governance agreement is terminated per the termination governance specified in the agreement itself, with the termination documented in the home substrate's governance record.
- **Step 5 — Governance portfolio update.** The home substrate's governance portfolio is updated to reflect the terminated relationships: agreements are closed, standing configurations are marked revoked, and relationship entries are updated to reflect their terminated status.
- **Step 6 — Network participation configuration update.** The network participation configuration is updated to remove the exiting relationships from the set of active participation preferences, closing the configuration-level inconsistency between the Self's stated participation preferences and its actual participation behavior.
- **Step 7 — Offboarding record production.** A complete offboarding record is produced in the home substrate, documenting all relationships closed, all agreements terminated, all configurations revoked, the effective date, and the notification record for each partner. This record is the governance closure artifact — the substrate content that makes the exit inspectable, traceable, and auditable.

Remediation of discovered silent offboarding. When a governance audit identifies an existing silent offboarding, remediation adapts D2.70 to a retroactive register. The governing Self conducts

an audit to identify all orphaned standing configurations and agreements, retroactively revokes each standing configuration through a governance act, formally terminates each cross-organizational agreement (or documents the gap where the agreement's termination governance cannot now be followed as specified), produces a retroactive offboarding record, and notifies affected partner Selves through formal channels. Retroactive remediation is more costly than prospective execution of D2.70, and it cannot fully close all consequences — partner trust calibration that was degraded by unexplained non-responsiveness cannot be rebuilt through a retroactive record alone. But it restores the governance integrity of the home substrate and gives partner Selves the formal record they need to close their own governance portfolio entries.

Category 1 Completion Note

AP-13 is the final anti-pattern in Phase D3's Category 1 taxonomy. Category 1 — Lifecycle Governance Failures — now has three formalized members: AP-11 (Governance Inception Failure), which addresses entry into inter-Self participation without adequate governance infrastructure; AP-12 (Configuration Drift), which addresses the failure of ongoing governance maintenance as operational conditions change; and AP-13 (Silent Offboarding), which addresses the failure of governed exit when participation ends. The three anti-patterns together cover the lifecycle of inter-Self participation at its three most critical governance junctures. Category 1 is complete.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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